

Pook's Tangled Paths

The emerald isles of the Celts roll green and misty between a silver sea and soft grey skies, dotted with thatched roundhouses, ancient oak groves, and rings of humming standing stones. Mist drifts over still lochs, and across it, just out of sight, lies the Land of Youth where no one grows old. The isles are full of gentle wonders: a playful shapeshifting faerie, a wise old salmon, a shy selkie of the loch, and four children long ago turned into singing swans. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is clever, listens kindly, and keeps a promise. The grandest deeds are done with cleverness and courage and a kind heart, and even a fearsome-seeming stranger, met with a friendly word, often turns out lonelier than it is unkind.



Pook's Tangled Paths

Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.

Before you begin

It is nearly time for the May fair. But the winding paths of the Whispering Oak Grove have gone all tangled. Soft ribbons of mist loop them over and round, and now the village folk cannot find their way to the fair.

Who did this? Pook the Puca, a playful faerie who can change his shape. He did not mean any harm. He only wanted a game.

Old Maeve the Tale-Weaver calls you to the Roundhouse. "You two have clever heads and kind hearts," she says. "Will you go and untangle the paths, and win Pook over with a friendly word?"

She gives you three gifts: a ball of red wool, a honey oatcake, and a sprig of oak for luck. Then she smiles. "Here we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being clever, brave, and kind."

What is your hero name? Are you a hero of Cleverness, of Courage, or of Kindness?

Stop 1: The Tangled Grove



You step into the grove. The paths loop and twist and double back on themselves. You walk and walk, and somehow you keep coming back to the same old oak tree.

It would be easy to get lost in here for ever.

What could you do? You have a ball of red wool. Could you tie one end at the start and follow it as you go? Then you can always find your way back.

When you tie the red wool at the start and unspool it behind you, you never lose your way. The grove cannot tangle a hero with a thread. Soon you find the path that leads deeper in.

Stop 2: Pook's Three Doors



The path opens into a clearing. There, Pook has grown three mossy doors out of oak branches, side by side. Only one door leads on. The others loop you straight back.

Pook pops up, a little furry shape with bright eyes, and gives you three teasing clues:

"The left door loves the morning sun, but it sends you back where you begun. The middle door is mossy and old, and it keeps a fib for every tale it told. The right door is quiet and small and true, and that is the door that will see you through."

Which door is the true one? Could you read his clues again, slowly? Could you ask him for a hint?

When you choose the right-hand door, it swings open with a happy creak. Pook giggles and somersaults away into the leaves. You step on through.

Stop 3: Winning Pook Over



Deeper in the grove you find Pook again, sitting on a toadstool. He has stopped laughing now. He hugs his knees and looks at his feet.

He made the whole grove into a game, and now he feels a little bit sorry. He did not think the village folk would be sad.

This is not a fight. What kind thing could you do? You have a honey oatcake to share. You could sit beside him. You could tell him the fair has room for him too. What do you try?

When you are kind to him and share the honey oatcake, Pook's eyes go warm and bright. "You are not cross with me?" he whispers. "Then I will set it all right."

The Paths Run True



Pook hops up and claps his furry paws. All across the grove, the ribbons of mist unwind and float away. The winding paths run straight and true again.

And Pook does not vanish this time. He skips along beside you, leading the way, proud to help at last. Down in the village, the folk cheer as the paths open, and the May fair begins with music and dancing.

High above the green isles, Danu the Kind looks down and smiles. You did it together. You were clever, you were brave, and most of all, you were kind. Well done, heroes.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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